

The Noble and Distinguished Dhāraṇī

Ārya-viśeṣavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 542 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 542 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-viśeṣavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Phags pa khyad par can zhes bya ba'i gzungs, which may be rendered into English as "The Noble and Distinguished One." As a dhāraṇī sūtra, it belongs to the broad class of canonical texts that transmit sacred formulae endowed with protective and liberating power, and its opening narrative situates the teaching within a specific time and place, recounting how a monk named Tshebrjod encountered an extraordinary vision during a journey. The text appears immediately following the dhāraṇī called "The Noble One Who Liberates from the Eight Great Fears," suggesting it was transmitted and compiled as part of a related cluster of protective dhāraṇī literature. It is preserved among the dhāraṇī collections of the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of scriptures regarded as the word of the Buddha.

One will also obtain an emanation body (nirmāṇakāya). Namaḥ sarva-vidyā. Siddhyantu me mantra-pāda svāhā. Here ends the dhāraṇī called "The Noble One Who Liberates from the Eight Great Fears."

In the language of India: Ārya-viśeṣavatī-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: the dhāraṇī called "The Noble and Distinguished One."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One, on the twentieth day of the winter month of the Year of the Snake, was dwelling in the land of Phugroṇcan, in the temple of the city called Siñco. At that time, a monk named Tshebrjod went to a place called Gnassong for a particular purpose. That monk had traveled a distance of one hundred leagues from the Chinese city, when he saw from afar a very large human body, thirty cubits tall and four spans broad. Upon seeing it, the monk Tshebrjod thought to himself: "Ah, this being has a great body. Surely this must be Mañjuśrī in youthful form." He then placed both knees on the ground, joined his palms toward that great figure standing there, bowed in reverence, and addressed the great figure with these words: "Are you indeed Mañjuśrī in youthful form? Is it truly you here?" Mañjuśrī replied: "Monk, it is so." The monk said: "Mañjuśrī, why are you here?" Mañjuśrī in youthful form replied:

"Monk, in this Jambudvīpa, various illnesses arise among sentient beings. Yakṣas, asuras, garuḍas, and gandharvas dwell on one face of Mount Meru, the king of mountains. Because of this, the light of the sun and moon is obscured, and the sun, the moon, the planets, and the stars at times do not appear in the sky. At such times the gods and asuras wage war, and when battle is joined, the gods are defeated and the asuras are victorious. Then spirits (bhūtas) and hungry ghosts (pretas), taking the forms of women, send illness among sentient beings — namely, diseases of the liver and spleen, small pox, fever, stomach ailments, tertian fever, quartan fever, quintan fever, sextan fever, diseases arising from wind, diseases arising from bile, diseases arising from phlegm, diseases arising from their combination, headache, boils, mange, heat disorders, eye diseases, and so forth. Furthermore, excessive rain and flooding, and untimely rains strip away the abundant harvest of crops, rob sentient beings of their vitality, and deplete their life force, strength, complexion, and physical form, so that all sentient beings in Jambudvīpa are entirely beset by various illnesses. Fierce lions, wolves, tigers, serpents, and other such beings in their forms rob sentient beings of their vitality. Since untimely ruin hovers close over the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa, it is very difficult to free sentient beings from illness. In this Jambudvīpa, among beings young, middle-aged, and old, thirty myriads will die.

Therefore I have come to you, monk. You must proclaim this Dharma teaching to all sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. And why? Because all sentient beings of Jambudvīpa long to be freed from every suffering that binds them. Therefore, monk, you must proclaim this sūtra to all sentient beings, and —"

strive earnestly to cultivate the root of virtue in all sentient beings. Have faith in the Three Jewels continuously without interruption. Venerate the gods. Make offerings of incense, flowers, and fragrant smoke to the stūpas of the Tathāgatas and to their sacred images. Learn also the special dhāraṇīs. For seven days, keep the eightfold restoration ceremony (poṣadha).

Homage to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Vipula-ghoṣarāja, King of Thunder Vast and Deep.

Tadyathā: vipula-garjite, vipula-svāre, vipula-yoniśe, analase,
anala-saṃbhave, anala-sa-gatiṃ gate svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata who utterly clears away all obscurations.

Tadyathā: hema hema, hama hama svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata Amitābha.

Tadyathā: amitod-bhave, amita-saṃbhabhave, amita-vikrānte,
amita-pikrāntikare, amita-gagana-kīrtikare svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata Source of Qualities.

Tadyathā: gagana-sa-ākāra, gagana-saṃbhavi, gagana-kīrte-kare svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata Supremely Fragrant on All Sides.

Tadyathā: sama-same svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata who has gone forth with the victory banner that none can withstand, whose thunder resounds.

Tadyathā: asama-same svāhā.

Homage to the Tathāgata Subduer of Pride.

Tadyathā: mana-viśuddhe, padmeśvare, padma-saṃbhave, kiṃkare, hitaṃ
kāriye svāhā.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Homage to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha who utterly clears away all obscurations.

Tadyathā: śvetakara-bhaijvaline svāhā. jambhane, stambhane, mohane svāhā.
pauṇḍarīkāya svāhā. home dharme, dharmācantāye svāhā. dhare-bhidhare,
kalaviṅka-rutaye svāhā. śānte-kāṇne-nirvāṇaṇye svāhā. dhuru dhuru,
viduru-dhiye svāhā. vimala-pracuṇḍāye svāhā. avalokita, vilokitāye svāhā.
ājñāna-pidhāmanyē svāhā. padma-svare, padma-saṃbhave, kiṃkare hitaṃ
kāriye svāhā.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Tadyathā: candra-prabhe, candana-garbhe, candana-cūrṇe, ke-kaila-savati,
sarva-buddha, adhiṣṭhita-anumodite svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the noble one Mañjuśrī.

Tadyathā: jaye jaye, jaya-labhe, jayaṃ hā-mahe svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Tadyathā: gagana-ārye, gagana-samuṅgate, gagana-vikrānta, vikrānta,
ejime-jī, padmo-jī svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva Samantabhadra.

Tadyathā: he bhadre, mahā-bhadre, ati-bhadre, samanta-bhadre,
vigata-rājase, mahā-vigata-rājase, ati-vigata-rājase, he-mavati,
karma-āvaraṇa-viśodhane svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the noble Maitreya.

Tadyathā: maitrī maitrī, maitrī-manase svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the noble Ākāśagarbha.

Tadyathā: garbhe, garbhe, garbha-viśodhane svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the noble Inexhaustible Intellect (Akṣayamati).

Tadyathā: akṣaye-nu, akṣaye-phu, akṣaya-karma-viśodhane phu svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva Renowned as the Stainless One.

Tadyathā: kīrtitā, sarva-jine, abhi-kīrtitā, sarva-jine, vajra-kare, vajra-saṃbhave, vajra-vedā-kāre svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva who utterly clears away all obscurations.

Tadyathā: sarvāparaṇa-viskaṃbhinye svāhā.

Dhātu-vikaraṇye svāhā. Megha-visphota-me svāhā. Aparājita-kāye svāhā. Bala-dadānye svāhā. Bodhyaṃ-dadānye svāhā. Karma-nirbhavita-kāye svāhā. Ekārāmāye svāhā. Yoga-cārāye svāhā. Sarva-buddhābhiṣiktāye svāhā. Brahmopakuṭāye svāhā. Sarva-dharmābhiṣiktāye svāhā. Sarva-buddhābhiṣiktāye svāhā. Ekaśṛṅgāye svāhā. Aśṛṅgrāye svāhā. Bhūtāye svāhā. Asaṃbhūtāye svāhā. Sarva-duḥkhopraśamanye svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva Candraprabha, the Youthful.

Tadyathā: candraprabhe, suprabhe, prabhākare, prabhodyate, prabhodyate, prabhavati, prabhavati, dharma-viśuddhe, karmā-viśuddhir bhavatu me svāhā.

Now, whoever, monk Āyusman, recites this dhāraṇī mantra seven times by day and seven times by night for seven days, all karmic obscurations without exception will be completely purified. One should offer food to seven monks. One should kindle fire from fire. At night, holding a lamp, one should pay homage at a stūpa and circumambulate it. One should be diligent in writing and reciting the sacred Dharma. If a great epidemic disease arises, one should offer incense from the land of Gandhāra, together with torma offerings and divine food cakes, going from house to house, from village to village, from city to city. And whoever is sick, if they perform this ritual accordingly, they will swiftly be freed from illness.

Then again Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke thus to the monk Āyusman: "Monk, whatever son or daughter of good family retains this Dharma text, recites it, copies it out in writing, causes it to be copied out in writing, or teaches it widely and correctly to others, that person will become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

Again Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke thus to the monk Āyusman: "This Dharma text should be sent from region to region, from city to city, from village to village, so that it may resound in the ears of all people."

Again Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke thus to the monk Āyusman: "Āyusman, whoever reads this Dharma text once will be liberated themselves. Whoever reads it twice will be liberated together with their children and spouse. Whoever reads it three times will be liberated together with the assembly of their kindred and relatives. Whoever reads it four times, all the surrounding region will also be liberated. Whoever reads it five times, that person along with the neighboring kings will be liberated."

Again Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke thus to the monk Āyusman: "This Dharma text should be sent quickly to other regions, and these same benefits will arise there as well. Āyusman, whoever hears this Dharma text yet does not retain it, does not recite it, does not copy it in writing, does not cause it to be copied in writing, does not master it thoroughly, does not teach it widely and correctly to others, does not send it forth to other regions, does not listen to it by sharing it in common with all sentient beings, and does not dedicate it to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — such a person will fully bring about a destiny equal to that of those who commit the five acts of immediate retribution, and will be condemned by all buddhas and bodhisattvas."

Again Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke thus to the monk Āyusman:

"Āyusman, whoever does not take this as a valid authority — such a person I did not originally inspire with faith. Therefore, in order that all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa may come to be at ease, go to Mount Meru, the king of snow mountains, and make diligent effort to teach the gods and gandharvas in accordance with this instruction and to establish it among them."

Having said these words, Mañjuśrī the Youthful instantly became invisible. The monk Āyusman, for his part, rejoiced in and took to heart what Mañjuśrī the Youthful had said, and departed.

This concludes the noble dhāraṇī called "The Distinctive One."

Translated by the Indian masters Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor-translator the venerable Ye shes sde, revised in accordance with the new language conventions, and established in final form.

Translator's Notes

- The text opens with a mantra passage in Sanskrit transliteration embedded in a Tibetan dhāraṇī text, immediately followed by a colophon and then a new dhāraṇī text beginning with its Sanskrit and Tibetan titles. The passage thus spans the close of one dhāraṇī and the opening of another. The place names Phugroṅcan, Siñco, and Gnassong appear to be transliterations of Chinese or Central Asian place names not yet firmly identified; they are rendered phonetically. The disease list follows classical Āyurvedic humoral categories (wind, bile, phlegm, and their combination), which the Tibetan preserves faithfully. "Thirty myriads" renders dkrings phrag sum cu, meaning thirty times ten thousand, i.e., three hundred thousand. The final sentence is incomplete as given and trails into a continuation not included in this passage.
- The passage is a liturgical sequence of homages paired with dhāraṇī mantras. The transliterated Sanskrit mantras are rendered as closely as the Tibetan orthography allows; some syllables reflect Tibetan phonetic approximations of Sanskrit and cannot be restored with complete certainty to a single Sanskrit original.

The name rendered "Source of Qualities" translates the Tibetan Tathāgata-name Yontan Jungné, a standard epithet meaning "arising-ground of qualities." The name rendered "Supremely Fragrant on All Sides" translates Künné Pöchok.

The instruction "keep the eightfold restoration ceremony for seven days" means observing the eight-precept poṣadha on each of seven consecutive days, a standard practice recommended in dhāraṇī sūtras.

"Ākāśagarbha" is the Sanskrit reconstruction of the Tibetan Namkhai Nyingpo, meaning "essence of space."

- The five acts of immediate retribution (पाँचानन्तर्याकर्म, Skt. pañcānantarya-karma) are the five gravest karmic offenses — killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha — whose perpetrators fall into hell without interval at death. The phrase here states that one who neglects this Dharma text will achieve a destiny equivalent to theirs, which is a strong rhetorical warning standard in this genre of text.

The term Āyuṣman (阿育曇) is a Vinaya honorific meaning "Venerable" or "long-lived one," used when a senior addresses a junior monk by name with this respectful title; it functions here essentially as a proper name in context.

- The phrase rendered "I did not originally inspire with faith" translates a somewhat compressed Tibetan construction. The sense is that Mañjuśrī disclaims having originally planted faith in anyone who fails to regard this dhāraṇī as a valid authority — meaning such a person falls outside the scope of his spiritual influence from the very beginning. The colophon names the standard trio responsible for many canonical translations of this period: the two Indian panditas Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the Tibetan lotsāwa Ye shes sde.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please

consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.